other bodies
WORKBOOK



Gratitude

This resource was made possible by the meaningful work of Shauna Kaendo, art therapist, whose creative care practice taught me that making things together is a form of healing.

It was deepened by the work of the Erotics of Liberation, whose eco-somatic framework gave me a language for bodies — human and more-than-human — as sites of wisdom.

It is offered with love to the ohHEY Creative Care Community — the people who show up, week after week, to make watercolour blobs together in the dark and the light.

This deck is part of an ongoing creative care practice documented at therapeuticstudio.ca.

A note on the natural bodies

Every natural body in this deck was chosen because it knows something about the emotion it accompanies — not as a symbol imposed from outside, but as a living, embodied wisdom. A snail retreating into its shell is not broken. A river in flood is not out of control. Moss growing over a fallen tree is not in denial.

These are not metaphors that explain your feelings away. They are companions that have been feeling something adjacent to this, in their own way, for millions of years. You are in good company.

What this resource is

This is a deck of 52 creative care prompts organized into ten feeling constellations — clusters of emotions that share a quality, a texture, a way of moving through the body.

Each card carries a natural body: an animal, a plant, a weather system, a geological formation, a creature of the deep or the forest floor. These are not illustrations of your feelings. They are companions for them — other bodies in the world that know something about what you are carrying, and have been carrying it, in their own way, for longer than we can imagine.

The prompt on each card is an invitation to make — not to make something good, not to make something finished, but to make something honest. Watercolour is suggested because it resists control in the most generous way. But any materials you have are the right materials.

A note on somatic practice

Before you draw a card or pick up a brush, you might take a moment to arrive in your body:

Feel the weight of yourself in your seat. Notice what is touching what — hands on the table, feet on the floor. Take one breath that is slightly slower than usual. Ask yourself, without needing a precise answer: what am I carrying right now?

This is enough. You have already begun.

This deck is not a diagnostic tool, a therapeutic assessment, or a replacement for professional mental health support. It is a creative care practice — a way of tending to yourself through image, attention, and the quiet companionship of the natural world. If you are working with difficult emotions and need additional support, please reach out to a qualified therapist or counsellor.

If you are in distress, please reach someone who can help now: in British Columbia, 310-6789 (no area code); anywhere in Canada, call or text 9-8-8.

The cards are grouped by feeling constellation — ten clusters of emotional states that share a common quality or texture:

01 **Protective states** — *shame, fear, numbness, withdrawal, guarded*
The emotions that draw us inward, build walls, or go quiet. Not broken responses — wise ones.

02 **Heavy states** — *grief, sadness, exhaustion, despair, heaviness*
The emotions that ask us to slow down, to be with what is hard, to let weight be weight.

03 **Relational states** — *loneliness, tenderness, longing, love, jealousy, betrayal*
The emotions that live in the space between us — what we feel in relation to others, real or imagined, present or absent.

04 **Activated states** — *anger, anxiety, urgency, frustration, restlessness*
The emotions that move fast, that carry heat, that push against edges. Energy looking for a direction.

05 **Self-directed states** — *self-doubt, inadequacy, pride, regret, guilt*
The emotions we turn on ourselves — some tender, some harsh, all asking for witness.

06 **Expansive states** — *joy, wonder, gratitude, awe, curiosity, excitement*
The emotions that open outward, that enlarge us, that remind us what it feels like to be alive and glad of it.

07 **Tender and quiet states** — *stillness, peace, contentment, safety, belonging*
The emotions that ask almost nothing — only that we notice them, rest in them, let them be enough.

08 **Complex and mixed states** — *ambivalence, overwhelm, confusion, hope, disappointment, nostalgia*
The emotions that resist simple naming — layered, contradictory, often the most honest of all.

09 **Relational repair states** — *forgiveness, vulnerability, trust, repair*
The emotions that arrive after rupture — fragile, essential, asking us to remain open.

10 **Existential and threshold states** — *uncertainty, change, grief for the world, the ache of not yet, alive*
The emotions that live at the edges of the self — where we meet time, mortality, mystery, and meaning.

How to use this resource

There is no wrong way. Here are some possibilities:

Draw intuitively. Shuffle the deck, hold a question lightly, and draw a card without looking. Trust what arrives.

Draw deliberately. If you already know what you are feeling, find the constellation that holds it and choose a card that names it. Let the natural body show you something you haven't seen yet.

Draw for the day. In the morning or evening, draw one card and let it be a companion — not something to act on immediately, but something to notice alongside.

Draw for a session. Before you sit down to paint, draw a card and let it set the conditions for your practice. You do not need to paint the natural body literally. Let the quality of it — its patience, its texture, its way of being — move through your brush.

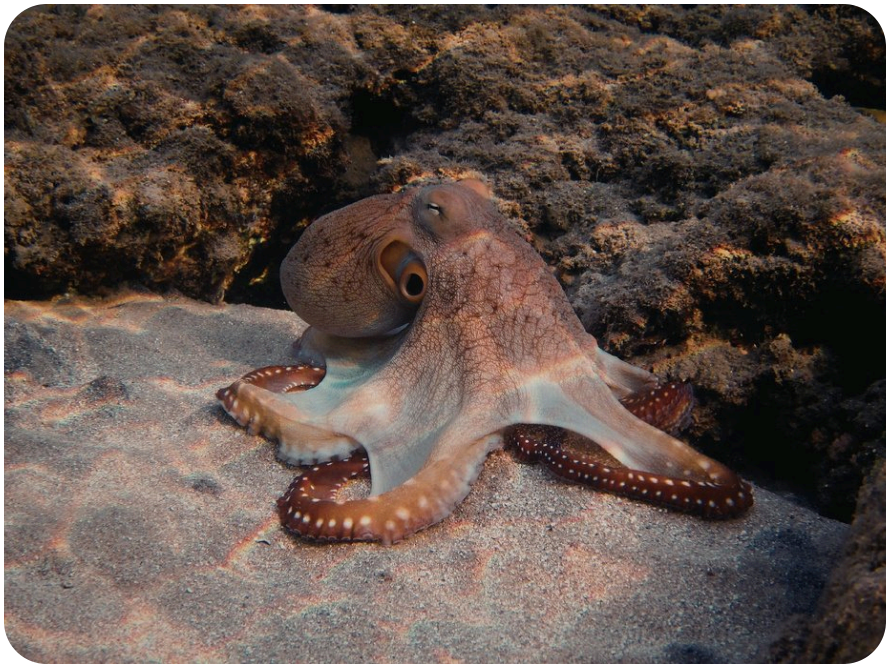
Draw for a friend. Sometimes we draw for someone we love. Let the card be a quiet offering — a way of saying *I see what you are carrying, and the world has a name for it.*

How to work with a prompt

Each prompt will invite you to:

1. **Notice** — turn your attention toward something in the natural world and feel its qualities in your body before you begin.
2. **Make** — let your materials respond to what you are noticing. Watercolour is suggested for its willingness to pool, spread, and surprise. But any materials you have are welcome here.
3. **Rest** — when you are finished, sit with what you made for a moment before you judge it. What is it holding? What did it know before you did?

You do not need to share what you make. You do not need to keep it. Making it was enough.



I feel ashamed.

Consider, for a moment, the octopus — soft-bodied, many-armed, slipping through the shifting blues of its underwater world. Watch how, with a thought, it changes its colour and pattern, not in the name of trickery, but as a living reply to the world's demands. Its skin, a canvas for feeling, reads the tides, the shadows, the presence of others, and answers in blushes of ochre, indigo, pearl. What seems like hiding is, in truth, exquisite sensitivity — a whole being tuned to the pulse of its surroundings.

With your brush, let your colours shift and mingle as freely as an octopus's skin. Let each watercolour bloom be a response, not a plan — a whisper of change, a flicker or a flush across the page. There is no need for a picture, no pressure to explain. Simply notice how you feel, and let your hand answer, mark by mark, in the language of colour.

As you paint, consider that what we sometimes call hiding or shame may be our own deep sensitivity — our bodies responding as best they can.



I feel afraid.

Imagine, for a while, the feeling of fear — not as a fault, but as a cave in the hillside of your own being. See how the cave does not turn its back on the world; instead, it opens a mouth to the air and offers its darkness as sanctuary. What enters is not lost, but held: in stillness, in quiet, in the slow hush of stone and shadow. Here, there is no demand to rush; here, every trembling thing is given space to breathe, to gather itself, to wait for the return of light.

With your brush, invite a wash of deep colour — let it pool, shadowed and gentle, across the page. Allow your hand to move without hurry or aim, letting darkness settle and expand, not as a hiding place, but as a cradle for whatever needs holding. There is nothing to fix, nothing to finish — only a space to dwell, to rest, to be with what is.

As you paint, let your practice be an act of offering: darkness as a kindness, a place where fear can soften and simply exist.



I feel numb.

Bring to mind the silent country of permafrost — earth that remains frozen, season after season, not from lack, but from a kind of careful keeping. Beneath its hard, cold surface lies the memory of forests, the roots of old grasses, seeds and bones and stories, all held in patient suspension. Permafrost is not empty; it is a vault, preserving whole worlds until the time comes for thaw and renewal. Numbness, too, is not absence. It is ancient storage — life held in trust, awaiting the warmth that will let it move again.

With your brush, lay down a wash of cool, pale colour. Let it settle, let it seem still and unmoving. Beneath the surface, invite other colours to creep and linger — hidden, waiting, quietly vibrant. There is no need for your marks to speak loudly or show themselves all at once. Allow space in your painting for what is unseen, for what rests beneath, for all that is being kept safe.

As you paint, notice if there are feelings, memories, or parts of yourself that have gone quiet, frozen for a while.



I feel withdrawn.

Turn your attention for a while to the tide pool, revealed at low tide — a quiet basin left behind as the great ocean draws its breath. Notice how, when the water recedes, the tide pool does not vanish or despair; it gathers itself, draws its small world closer. Sheltered within a cradle of stone, it holds seaweed and anemone, crab and shell, all the colors and textures of life condensed and waiting.

With your brush, let your colours pool and concentrate. Allow the paint to collect in gentle hollows, to mingle and rest in small, bright gatherings. There is no need to make a picture of the tide pool — only to notice what it feels like to hold space, to keep company with yourself when the world pulls away. Let each mark be a kind of gathering-in, a quiet act of presence, a way of tending to what remains.

As you paint, remember the patience of the tide pool: how it endures, how it shelters its ecosystem, how it trusts the ocean's return.



I feel guarded.

Turn your attention to the pine cone, nested among needles, enduring the dry heat of the afternoon. Notice how, beneath the harsh glare and crackle of thirst, it draws its scales tight — not as a denial of the world, but as a quiet act of discernment. The seeds within are not lost; they are protected, waiting for the kindness of rain, for the moment when the air softens and the earth says, now.

With your brush, lay down a wash that feels parched — ochres, siennas, faded greens. Let your marks curl inward, gathering themselves, edges drawn close. There is no need for your painting to open or to spill itself — let it hold, let it keep something safe inside. This is not refusal, but wisdom: a knowing of what must wait, a promise that opening will come when it is safe.

As you paint, rest in the understanding that guardedness is its own form of care.



I feel grief.

Let your thoughts settle on moss — a green hush spreading over stones, fallen logs, the quiet remains of what once stood upright. Notice how moss does not rush to erase what has come undone. Instead, it gathers gently along the edges of ruin, softening splinters, cloaking the broken in velvet patience. Moss turns decay into something bearable, a small act of kindness for the past, making room for what the present brings.

With your brush, invite a slow, spreading green, letting the paint creep and linger over the paper's surface. Do not hurry to cover or correct; let your colours settle softly, holding space for what is imperfect, for what has weathered and worn. There is no need to disguise the rough patches — let them show, let them be gently cradled by your marks.

As you paint, consider how moss teaches the art of living with what cannot be fixed.



I feel sad.

Turn your gaze to the hush of still water, its surface unbroken until the rain arrives — each drop a brief insistence, a gentle shattering. Rain does not pause at the edge nor hesitate to touch; it simply falls, and in falling, sends ripples out in all directions. There is no apology, no need to smooth what is stirred. The disturbance is honest, each circle widening, overlapping, until the water settles once again.

With your brush, let a wash of colour rest quietly across the page, then invite other drops to fall — a touch here, a touch there — watching as the pigment spreads, sending out its own small waves. Don’t worry if the surface is disrupted, if the marks run into one another or blur; this is the truth of rain on water. The ripples are real, and they matter, even as they pass.

As you paint, allow yourself to notice what happens when you disturb your own stillness.



I feel exhausted.

Let your thoughts follow the long journey of a river, winding its way from distant mountains, gathering speed and purpose as it carves through stone and valley. In time, the river finds its end — not in disappearance, but in transformation. At the delta, the water slows, spreads, embraces the wide open, and divides itself into many channels, each carrying its own silt and story. This is not failure, but fulfillment: the gentle unfolding at the journey's end, where the river makes new land, rich with possibility.

With your brush, lay down a wash that travels — moving, branching, gradually slowing as it reaches the edges of the page. Let your colours spread and mingle, forming pools and fingers, each one a quiet celebration of arrival. Do not rush to contain or direct them; let the paint settle and divide as it will, marking the place where movement becomes rest, and striving gives way to abundance.

As you paint, consider your own journeys and the places where you have slowed, where you have allowed yourself to open and change.



I feel despair.

Bring to mind the silent silhouette of a dormant volcano, rising out of the land — its slopes softened by years of wind and rain, a mountain mistaken for calm. Yet beneath that stillness, deep within the earth, heat persists: not vanished, only waiting. The fire is held close, pressure building quietly, tracing secret paths through stone, biding its time for the moment when it must speak.

With your brush, let a wash of muted colour form the broad, gentle shape of rest. Beneath the surface, invite threads of warmth — quiet reds, glowing ochres, the suggestion of hidden heat — hinting at what lives below. There is no need for eruption, no need for spectacle; simply hold the presence of what is powerful, contained, and patient.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself where energy waits, where feeling simmers beneath the calm of everyday.



I feel heaviness.

Turn your attention to clay soil after rain — earth dark and dense, heavy with the memory of water. Even when the storm has wandered on and the sky has cleared, the clay remains saturated, holding tight to every drop. This is not stubbornness, but a kind of devotion; the soil keeps what it has been given, letting the moisture seep slowly, patiently, into its depths. In time, with sun and air, the clay loosens, softens, and what was once held so tightly becomes nourishment for roots, for seeds, for all that grows.

With your brush, lay down a wash that feels full and slow — colours pooling and settling, edges blurred by the weight of what they contain. Let your paint linger on the page, not in a hurry to dry or move on. Notice what it feels like to be saturated, to hold experience within yourself, letting it rest and soak until it is ready to be released.

As you paint, allow the act to be an acceptance of fullness — of all you carry, all you have absorbed.



I feel lonely.

Consider, for a moment, the vastness of the deep ocean, where darkness is near-total and silence complete. Down here, beyond the reach of the sun, companionship is a rare and passing gift. Yet in this utter dark, certain creatures begin to glow — soft pulses of blue or green, a radiance that is not borrowed or reflected, but born within. They shine not for an audience, nor as a call, but simply because light is what they are made of. Loneliness, here, does not extinguish what is luminous; it is sometimes the only condition dark enough to reveal it.

With your brush, begin with a wash of the deepest blues, indigos, the shadowed colours of the ocean's depth. Then, with a lighter touch, let small blooms of bright colour emerge — delicate, unexpected — spreading quietly into the darkness around them. Your painting is not for display; it is simply the act of allowing what glows in you to come forward, no matter how softly or briefly.

As you paint, trust that your own luminousness is not lost in solitude.



I feel tender.

Let your thoughts drift beneath the forest floor, where darkness and damp hold a hidden network — mycelium weaving its fine threads through earth and root, binding the living to the dead, the strong to the struggling. Here, in the hush beneath all growing things, nourishment passes quietly from what is abundant to what is in need. Mycelium does not show itself, nor does it seek praise. Its tenderness is silent, persistent — a gift of connection, invisible yet essential.

With your brush, lay down a gentle wash — soft browns, muted greens, a whisper of grey. Let thin lines and pale trails wander slowly through the wetness, crossing and meeting, then drifting apart again. There is no need for clarity or centre; let your marks suggest a world beneath, patient and alive, supporting what is seen above.

As you paint, consider the acts of tenderness that may never be noticed, the ways you nourish and are nourished, wordlessly, every day.



I feel longing.

Turn your mind to a lone migratory bird, lingering beneath a sky that offers neither the warmth of return nor the promise of departure. Out of season, it waits, uncertain, yet the longing it feels is not a failing nor a whim. This yearning is etched in bone and feather — a pull toward an elsewhere that is as real as the air it breathes. The bird does not invent its longing; it is fidelity to a place, a time, a rhythm written into the body itself.

With your brush, lay down a wash that travels — soft sweeps of blue or grey, restless but sure, moving across the page without clear destination. Let the colours drift, pause, and gather, echoing the sense of waiting, of being between. Your painting need not arrive anywhere, nor must it resolve; let it be a record of longing that is neither restlessness nor mistake, but the honest work of being true to what calls you.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself where longing lives — not as a flaw, but as a quiet faithfulness to what is real, even if it is not yet here.



I feel love.

Turn your thoughts to the river as it journeys toward the sea, each bend and eddy shaped by the quiet force of longing. The river does not choose to love the sea — this movement is written into its very being. It follows the pull without question, patient with every detour, carving new channels when the way is blocked, never doubting the direction, only knowing that love draws it onward.

With your brush, let a gentle wash of colour meander across the page, flowing easily and then pausing, turning where it must, finding a path around every obstacle. Let your paint move with its own quiet certainty — sometimes quick, sometimes slow, always moving toward something deeper. There is no need to plan or strive; trust that what you feel will guide the marks you make.

As you paint, rest in the knowledge that love, too, is not a decision but a current — a force that shapes and reshapes you, that carves new ways through your life, that is patient, persistent, and sure.



I feel jealous.

Let your thoughts settle for a moment on a plant in a dim room, stretching silently toward the single window, its leaves and stems bending in patient pursuit of light. This reaching is not greed, but simple honesty — a quiet declaration of need, a willingness to grow in the direction of what sustains. The plant does not apologize for its longing; it leans, day by day, toward brightness, because survival asks for nothing less. And so too, jealousy sometimes arises when longing has nowhere else to look — its root not malice, but a hunger for what is needed and rare.

With your brush, lay a gentle wash of colour that reaches — let your marks lean or curve toward a pale patch on the page, following the imagined path of sunlight. Allow your painting to stretch, to bend, to gather itself in the direction of what calls it forward. There is no need for symmetry or restraint; let your colours be drawn, honestly, toward what would sustain them.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself that lean toward light, that turn, unashamed, toward hope or comfort or love.



I feel betrayed.

Let your thoughts rest on the soil after wildfire, blackened and bare beneath a sky washed clean by flame. At first glance, it seems all has been lost — what once grew here is ash, what once sheltered is gone. Yet beneath the scorched surface, life endures in quiet persistence. The ground remembers how to hold moisture, how to cradle seeds. It is not ruined, only changed. What was built here has passed; what will grow next remains unknown. Still, the earth endures, waiting, patient, quietly alive.

With your brush, lay down a wash dark as charcoal, letting it sit heavy on the page. Beneath this, allow hints of softer colour to seep through— greens, golds, the faintest blush of new beginnings — emerging slowly, almost hidden. Do not hurry to cover the darkness or disguise the loss. Let your painting hold both what was burned and what still lives below.

As you paint, consider the places in your own life marked by loss or change — where what once was is gone, and what comes next is still unseen.



I feel angry.

Let your mind turn to the river in flood — banks overtopped, waters rushing with a force that cannot be denied. This is not simple destruction, nor blind rage. The river moves with purpose, carrying away what has gathered and blocked its path for too long. Branches, silt, stones — each caught in the current, swept forward by necessity. There is a wildness here, yes, but also a clear knowing: the river remembers its shape and seeks to find it again.

With your brush, let your colours surge and sweep across the page. Paint with movement, with weight, letting pigment gather and run, carrying with it whatever it finds — old marks, sediment, the traces of what came before. Do not fear the chaos; let it speak of what must move, of what must finally be released.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself where feeling has built up, where something long-blocked now presses to be set free.



I feel anxious.

Let your thoughts drift upward to a murmuration of starlings — thousands of wings flickering against the evening sky, weaving and folding in patterns that seem both wild and gentle. No single bird knows the shape of what they make together; the flock turns and dips, responding to the subtle cues of neighbour and breeze. There is no fixed destination, only the constant shifting, the willingness to stay close, to trust the movement even when the direction is uncertain. Out of this unknowing, something beautiful emerges — coherence from chaos, belonging from drift.

With your brush, let loose a constellation of marks — scattered, swirling, gathering and parting as they will. Allow your colours to move in response to each other, to group, to drift apart, to find new forms in the space between. There is no need for a plan; let your painting echo the flock, each gesture a response, a keeping-close, a trust in what will come.

As you paint, consider the moments in your own life when you have not known the way forward, but have moved anyway — guided by instinct, by the presence of others, by the hope that beauty can arise from uncertainty.



I feel urgency.

Turn your attention to the salmon running upstream, muscle and will pressed against the rush and tumult of water. This is not panic, nor flight; it is an answer to a call sounded deep within the bones, a summons that brooks no argument. The salmon leaps and strains, guided by something older than thought, urgency rising not from fear, but from the certainty of purpose — a life's meaning condensed into swift, determined motion.

With your brush, let your colours surge upward — quick strokes, bold splashes, the unmistakable sense of direction and drive. Let the paint move fast across the page, carving a path against the current, energy gathering at each mark. There is no need for caution or pause; let your hand answer the call, letting urgency become movement, and movement become expression.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself where urgency is not anxiety, but the bright pull of purpose — where you are carried by what must be done, what calls you to action without hesitation.



I feel frustrated.

Turn your thoughts to water as it meets a blocked path, the easy course suddenly denied. Yet water does not halt in defeat. It presses gently at every edge, pools with quiet patience, listens for a weakness or a seam. If no way is offered, it waits, gathering itself in stillness, certain that time or persistence will open the way. There is no shame in the pause, no hurry in the pressure. What seems like frustration is only water biding its time, learning the shape of what resists it, until — inevitably — it finds or makes a passage through.

With your brush, lay down a wash that pools and spreads, then encounters a barrier — a ridge of dry paper, a line of unmoving colour. Let your paint test the edges, linger in the hollows, spill slowly, seeking its own route. Do not force a breakthrough; let the water show you its patience, its quiet insistence, its willingness to wait and to try again.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself where frustration gathers, where progress is slowed by obstacles not of your making.



I feel restless.

Let your mind turn to the tides — ceaseless, never still, drawn onward and back by the silent gravity of distant moons. The tide does not apologize for its restlessness, nor does it mourn its inability to settle. It is not broken for moving; it is faithful to a rhythm larger than itself, governed by a pull so vast and ancient it cannot be denied. What appears as unease is only the body remembering the cycles it belongs to, the way water remembers the moon.

With your brush, lay down washes that rise and fall across the page — colours that surge forward, then withdraw, never quite coming to rest. Let your marks ebb and flow, overlapping and returning, allowing repetition and motion to shape your painting. There is no need for a final stillness; let the movement be its own truth, an honouring of the restless tide within.

As you paint, consider the times when your own body cannot be quiet, when you are drawn to movement for reasons you cannot name.



I feel doubt.

Let your thoughts rest for a moment on a young tree caught in the wind. See how it bends — perhaps too far, trembling at the edge of what seems possible, its slender trunk swaying wildly beneath the weight of the storm. It looks uncertain, precarious even, but this bending is not weakness. Each gust presses the roots deeper, each moment of doubt teaching the tree how to hold fast to the earth that sustains it. What seems like frailty is the slow work of strength being woven, the quiet labour of belonging more fully to the ground.

With your brush, let your colours arc and waver across the page — lines that lean, shapes that curve and twist, marks that seem almost to topple. Do not correct the unsteadiness; let your painting record the dramatic bending, the places where you felt pushed or stretched. Allow some colours to anchor themselves below, spreading and thickening, as roots do in searching for steadiness.

As you paint, consider the storms of self-doubt that shake you.



I feel inadequate.

Let your gaze settle on lichen clinging to bare rock — a small, persistent presence where there is almost nothing to begin with. No soil, no shelter, only the hard certainty of stone and the uncertain promise of air and light. Lichen does not wait for the world to become gentle or easy. It begins, quietly, with what little it has, and by its patient work, starts to turn the impossible into home. Inadequacy, here, is not failure, but simply earliness — the beginning of what might one day flourish.

With your brush, lay down a wash of grey or muted stone, and then, with gentle taps or spreading stains, let small outposts of colour appear — soft greens, pale golds, a slow, quiet expansion. Let your marks be tentative, scattered, unhurried. There is no need to fill the page or to prove abundance; let your painting honour the courage of beginnings, the resilience of what grows with almost nothing.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself that feel too small, too early, not enough.



I feel proud.

Turn your gaze to a tree standing in the fullness of its canopy, branches spread wide, leaves casting a generous shade upon all beneath. This abundance was not hurried — no branch forced, no ring added by impatience. Year by year, the tree grew, silent in its perseverance, layering strength and memory beneath its bark. Now, in its season of fullness, it gives freely — shelter, coolness, a home for birds and rest for wanderers — yet loses nothing of itself in the giving. Pride, here, is not arrogance, but the quiet acknowledgment of rings: each a testament to endurance, to weathering, to slow and patient becoming.

With your brush, let colours gather and expand — broad washes, layered greens, arcs that stretch across the page, overlapping in gentle abundance. Allow your painting to grow outward from a quiet centre, each mark a ring, a season, a record of arrival. There is no need to rush or to fill every space; let your work unfold at its own pace, generous but unforced.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself where you have earned your rings — where patience and persistence have shaped you, where you can stand in quiet fullness without apology.



I feel regret.

Let your mind linger on a river that has, over the years, shifted its course — finding a new way through the land not out of error, but in answer to change. The landscape tilted, stones moved, banks collapsed, and the river, true to its nature, followed where it was drawn. The old channel remains — a quiet scar, a memory of water's earlier passage, woven into the geography rather than erased. There is no shame in the turn, no need to hide what once was. Both paths belong to the story of the river.

With your brush, lay down a wash that winds and bends, then, beside it, another line — fainter, softer, a ghost of the first, curving through the paper's white. Let your colours drift, overlap, diverge. There is no need to choose or correct; let each channel be visible, each course honoured for what it carried.

As you paint, consider the times you have had to change direction — not because you were lost, but because the world shifted and you followed.

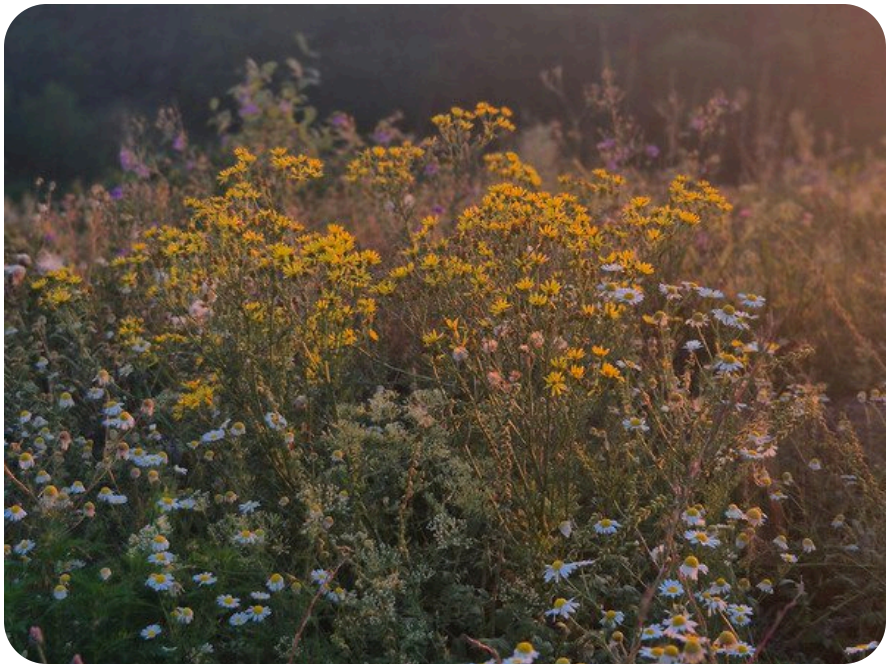


I feel guilt.

Turn your thoughts to the meadow after a storm — branches bent, leaves scattered, grass pressed flat by the restless passage of wind and rain. The storm did not linger to count what it disturbed, nor did it pause to claim victory or to apologize. It moved through, spent itself completely, and left what it left. The broken stems, the new light on the wet earth — these are real, shaped by the storm's wild energy. Yet the storm cannot undo them, nor can it prevent the slow, persistent return of the meadow to itself — green shoots rising, birdsong resuming, the ordinary work of recovery beginning again.

With your brush, lay down a wash that sweeps across the page — bold, loose, uncontained. Let your marks bend, scatter, break apart, making room for emptiness and aftermath. Then, with gentler strokes, invite the beginnings of return — soft greens, small uprisings, the subtle evidence of endurance.

As you paint, let yourself consider the truth of guilt: the ache of knowing that something real happened, that your passing left a mark, held alongside the understanding that, like the storm, you were being yourself as you adapt and change.



I feel joy.

Turn your gaze to a field of wildflowers after a long, soaking rain. See how they lift their heads in sudden colour, petals unfurling with no plan, no consultation, no signal but the long-awaited touch of water and light. Each blossom responds on its own, and yet the field blooms together, riotous and uncoordinated, a chorus of arrival without rehearsal or permission. There is no calculation here, no careful timing — only the honest answer to what has been needed for so long. Joy, too, can appear this way: not summoned or chosen, but arriving all at once, the whole field of you opening in response to what is finally enough.

With your brush, let your colours burst across the page — spontaneous, bright, scattered wherever the impulse lands. Let each mark be its own bloom, unconcerned with order or symmetry. Allow the washes to mingle and overlap, a celebration of suddenness, of joyful chaos, of the freedom to open without waiting for approval.

As you paint, consider the moments when joy has come upon you unexpectedly — when something in your spirit responded, not from decision, but from sheer relief or gladness.



I feel wonder.

Let your mind descend to the deep ocean, where a whale lifts its voice in the blue twilight, sending song into water thick with distance and silence. The notes travel, not hurried, but sure — carried through cold, through pressure, through darkness that would seem to swallow all sound. Yet the song continues, undiminished by the journey, until — miles and miles away — another whale hears it, recognizes the pattern, answers in turn. This is the marvel: that something true can move so far, and that in the vastness, there is always the possibility of being heard.

With your brush, lay down a deep wash, a wide ocean of colour. Let gentle waves and long, sweeping marks rise and fall across the page, a visual echo of distant music. Allow a single line or tone to travel — unbroken, persistent — across the wetness, reaching for the far edge. Do not worry if it seems to disappear or thin; trust that somewhere, it may yet arrive.

As you paint, consider the moments in your own life when you have sent something true into the world — an offering, a hope, a song — and wondered if it would find a listener.

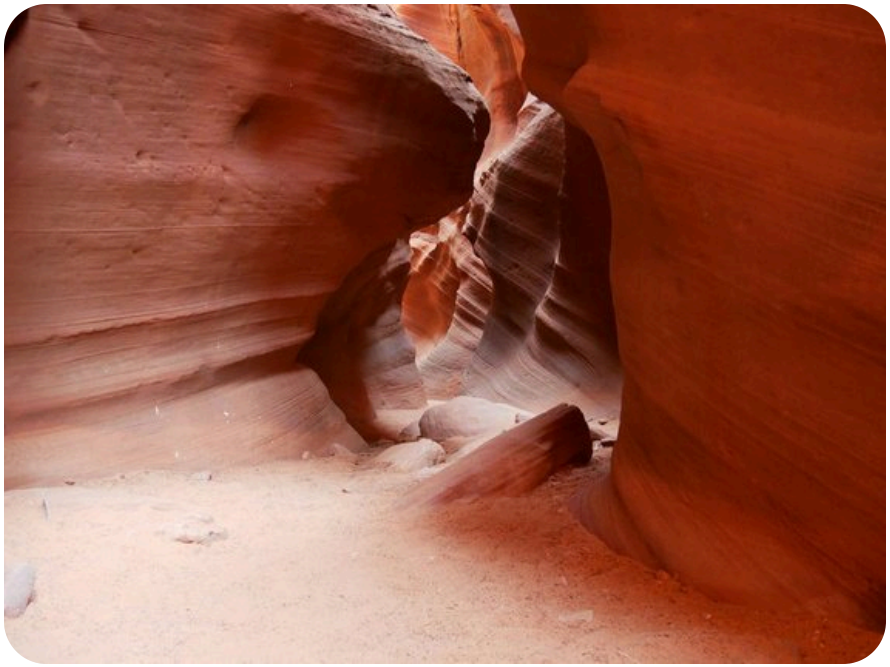


I feel grateful.

Let your gaze rest on a tree in autumn, its branches loosening their grip as the days grow shorter and the air sharpens with coming cold. See how the leaves, once held so tightly, now drift down in quiet spirals, gold and crimson, returning to the earth without sorrow or regret. The tree does not grieve what it lets go; it offers its leaves back to the ground that nourished them, a gesture of gratitude that knows holding on is not the measure of love. Each leaf is released with full acknowledgment of what was given — sunlight caught, rain gathered, shelter made — and is offered back to become soil, to feed roots, to ready the tree for another season.

With your brush, let colour fall gently onto the page — warm golds, reds, and browns, scattered and layered as if by wind. Let your marks drift and settle, accumulating softly, not in haste but in quiet acceptance. There is no need to gather or arrange them; let your painting be a record of release, an honouring of what has been given and now returns.

As you paint, consider all you have received and all you are ready to let go — not with sadness, but with gratitude.



I feel awe.

Let your gaze settle on the edge of a canyon — sheer, vast, carved by the endless, quiet work of water moving through stone. The canyon does not strive to impress; it is not hurried or ostentatious. Its grandeur is simply the patient accumulation of years upon years, each passing storm, each trickle and torrent contributing to the slow unveiling of depth and form. In standing at such an edge, you meet the evidence of patience far older and larger than your life — shapes and shadows made not by force, but by the steady, persistent attention of time.

With your brush, lay down a wash that suggests distance and depth — broad sweeps of earth and shadow, lines that drop away into the unknown. Let your colours layer and pause, shaped by what is left unpainted as much as by what is filled in. Allow the slow movement of water and pigment to echo the ancient work that shaped the canyon, building form through patience rather than speed.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself shaped not by sudden change, but by the long, steady passage of time — by what you have endured, by what you have waited for.



I feel curious.

Let your thoughts settle beneath the surface, where a root, pale and persistent, feels its way through the dark. It does not begin with a map, nor does it fret over certainty. Instead, it follows what it senses — moisture, warmth, a seam of possibility — changing direction without apology, splitting and reaching, finding nourishment in the least likely places. The stone it encounters does not halt it; the root simply bends, presses on, testing every crevice until it finds a way through. This is not stubbornness, but the quiet, relentless work of curiosity: seeking, feeling, moving forward, ever open to surprise.

With your brush, let a line or wash begin anywhere on the page. Allow it to twist and turn, branching out, doubling back, changing course as the paper offers resistance or invitation. Do not plan the path; let your painting find its own way, trusting the instinct to reach, to explore, to discover. Let new colours appear where you least expect them, small bursts of life in stony ground.

As you paint, consider the questions that pull you forward, the places where you have changed direction, the wonders you have found by following what called to you.



I feel excited.

Let your thoughts turn to the bee, small and tireless, who stumbles upon a field in the wild riot of full bloom. For the bee, discovery is not something to be kept in secret or stored away for leaner days. It returns at once to the hive, carrying not just pollen but news — its whole body alive with the urgency of translation, performing the age-old waggle dance. In circles, in trembling lines, it tells of direction, of distance, of abundance: a message too rich to be held alone. Excitement, in this way, is the body's own dance — the irrepressible impulse to share what overflows, to let movement become meaning, to make joy visible.

With your brush, lay down bursts of colour — sudden, bright, alive with energy that spills and overlaps. Let your hand move with the quickness of discovery, marks darting, circling, doubling back, translating the feeling of "too good to keep to myself" onto the page. There is no need to restrain or order; let excitement move through you, making its own sense in motion and hue.

As you paint, remember the moments when delight refused to be quiet, when news or beauty or hope radiated through you and demanded expression.



I feel still.

Let your mind rest upon a deep lake in winter, its surface stilled beneath a skin of ice, the world above made quiet by cold. Yet look deeper, past the brittle shimmer—there, the water moves at its own slow pace, fish drift and turn, and the secret work of life endures. The silence above is not a sign of emptiness, but of aliveness turned inward, of the world conserving itself for the seasons yet to come. Stillness here is not absence, but presence in another form, a gentle patience that holds all that lives beneath the frozen calm.

With your brush, lay down a wash of pale blues and muted silvers, a soft hush across the page. Then, beneath this quiet surface, let deeper colours bloom and move — shadows, currents, the suggestion of hidden motion. Let some marks linger in the depths, unseen at first glance but quietly vibrant, a record of the life that continues even in apparent stillness.

As you paint, consider the times you have felt quiet, not for lack of feeling but because your aliveness was gathering inward, conserving, waiting.



I feel peaceful.

Let your thoughts settle on a meadow after a long, soaking rain — the grass bowed but unbroken, each blade glistening, the air newly alive with the scent of petrichor. There is no proclamation of relief here, no song or spectacle; the meadow simply opens itself, pores wide, quietly absorbing what it has thirsted for. The ground grows supple, the roots remember their depth, and the world breathes differently for a while. Peace, in this place, is not the absence of weather, nor the forgetting of storms. It is the body after weather, breathing again, replenished and receptive, holding the memory of rain in every cell.

With your brush, lay down a gentle wash — greens, golds, earth softened by water. Let drops and pools of colour mingle and settle, as rain does in the hollows of the field. Allow the marks to rest, unhurried, each one a quiet intake, a silent welcome to what has come at last.

As you paint, consider the moments when peace has found you — not as a denial of trouble, but as a slow release, a readiness to receive what you needed.



I feel content.

Let your mind wander to a bear in late autumn, fur thick with the memory of sun and berry, body heavy with the patient labour of the season. The trees have shed their leaves, the air is edged with chill, and the earth is quieting itself for winter's long embrace. The bear does not rush or strive now; it feels the fullness of enough. There is still more to come — cold nights, deep sleep, the hush of snow — but here, in this pause, the bear has what it needs. Contentment is not the end of wanting, but the gentle interval between seasons, the deep breath before descent.

With your brush, let colours gather slowly — warm browns, soft golds, the muted greens of moss and pine. Allow your marks to settle and spread, unhurried, building a quiet abundance on the page. Let there be space in your painting for rest, for the slow certainty of having gathered enough, for the ease that comes when striving ceases, if only for a moment.

As you paint, consider the pauses in your own life, the times when you have found yourself with enough — not finished, not empty of desire, but content in the fullness of now.



I feel safe.

Let your thoughts wander to the heart of an old growth forest, where towering trunks rise out of moss and shadow, each ring a testament to seasons endured. Here, the air is thick with memory and the hush of green; the canopy weaves its own weather, softening sun and storm alike. Beneath the surface, roots tangle and clasp, binding tree to tree, earth to earth — silent agreements made in the dark. This forest does not owe its safety to the absence of threat, but to the depth of its entanglement: branches sheltering, roots holding, every life joined with another in quiet, persistent belonging.

With your brush, lay down layers of quiet colour — deep greens, browns that anchor, gentle misty washes above. Let your marks overlap and interlace, painting not just trees but the spaces between: the cradle of undergrowth, the hush beneath the branches, the sense of being held from all sides. Allow your work to grow dense, to become a place where light and shadow touch but do not disturb.

As you paint, consider where you are most entangled — who or what holds you, not by keeping danger out, but by rooting you deeply in connection.



I feel belonging.

Let your thoughts follow a river as it winds its way through cities and forests, marshes and meadows, sometimes lost from sight, sometimes breaking into sudden view. No matter how far the river travels, how much it wanders, it is always claimed by its watershed — drawn homeward by the unseen embrace of the land that gathers every tributary and drop. The river's belonging is not measured by how near it runs, but by the invisible catchment that shaped it from the start, the patient network of soil and slope, rainfall and root, that holds it in quiet certainty.

With your brush, let water and colour flow freely across the page, branching and joining, sometimes straying, sometimes pooling. Allow your painting to wander, to appear lost, yet always returning — pulled by the gentle logic of the land beneath. Do not try to contain every movement; trust that whatever path your marks may take, they are held by something larger and unseen.

As you paint, consider the places and people who have claimed you — those whose presence shapes your course, whether or not you are close by.



I feel ambivalent.

Let your mind settle at the threshold of the estuary, where river meets sea in a restless mingling. Here, the water is neither wholly fresh nor wholly salt — each tide brings negotiation, each current holds a tension of opposites. The estuary is not a place of certainty, yet it is alive with possibility: reeds and rushes, shells and wings, creatures thriving in the shifting blend. Ambivalence, too, is not weakness; it is the honest meeting of two truths, each real, neither erased. In this mixing, new worlds emerge — life abundant, not in spite of complexity, but because of it.

With your brush, let fresh colours bleed into salt — soft washes of blue meeting green, hints of gold or grey, edges blurring and re-forming as the water does. Let your painting hold the mingling, the uncertainty, the beauty that comes from not choosing one or the other. There is no need to resolve every boundary; let your marks linger where things combine, where tides turn, where possibility is highest.

As you paint, consider the places within yourself where two realities meet —where ambivalence lives, not as confusion, but as the fertile crossing of currents.



I feel overwhelmed.

Let your thoughts wander to the forest floor after heavy snowfall, where drifts pile thick and white, weighing down branches and blanketing the hush of earth. The trees do not resist; they bend, some branches even break, yet beneath the soft burden, life persists. Roots hold firm in the dark, mycelium threads continue their silent work, and seeds rest in patient waiting. Overwhelm is not collapse, but the bearing of more than usual — the quiet strength of an ecosystem that endures beneath what appears too much.

With your brush, lay down a wash of pale, wintry colour — soft whites, cool blues, a gentle heaviness settling over the page. Let some marks yield or bow, some lines break, but allow hints of dark green, warm brown, or hidden gold to show beneath the snow. Paint both the weight and what remains unbroken—the quiet assurance of roots holding steady out of sight.

As you paint, consider the times you have felt buried, pressed down by more than you thought you could hold.

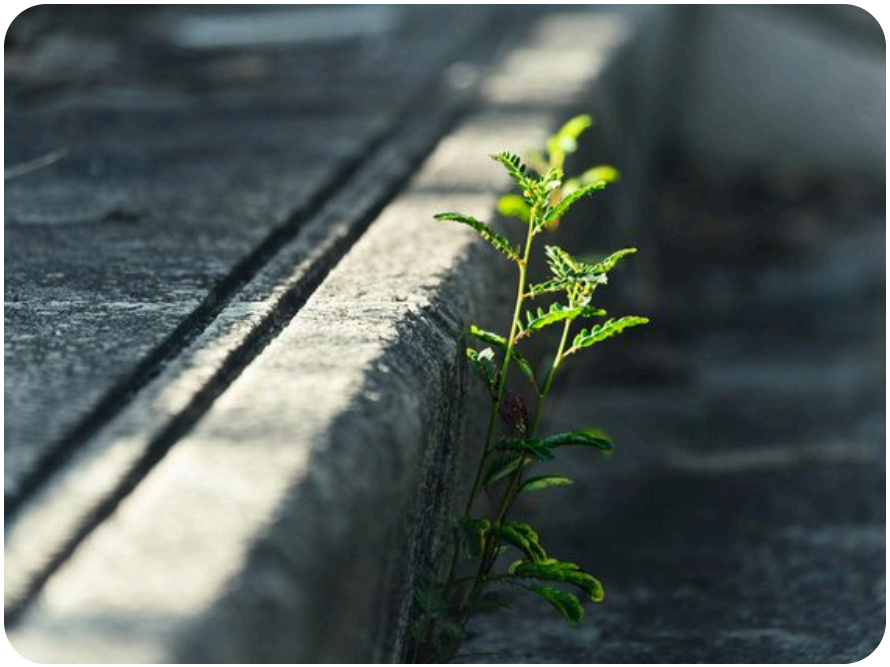


I feel confused.

Let your mind drift to a valley at dawn, where fog moves with quiet intent, softening the edges of field and forest, river and stone. The fog does not come to make things difficult; it is simply water between states, neither fully cloud nor yet rain, searching for its shape as it travels low and slow. The familiar becomes mysterious, boundaries slip away, and the world waits for definition to return. Confusion, too, is not failure of thought, but the mind in its moment between forms — midway through transformation, not yet cloud, not yet rain, simply finding its way.

With your brush, spread pale washes across the page — greys, soft blues, the gentle blur of things half-seen. Let edges dissolve, shapes overlap, details retreat into mist. Paint without hurry, allowing space for uncertainty, for what is still coming into being. Let your marks drift and settle, trusting that clarity will come in its own time.

As you paint, consider the times when you have found yourself in fog — uncertain, not for lack of effort, but because you are in motion, between what was and what will be.



I feel hopeful.

Let your gaze fall upon a green shoot rising through cracked pavement — a slender insistence, bright and vulnerable, pushing upward where no soil was meant to stay. This shoot is not naive; it does not mistake the hardness of its world, nor pretend the odds are kind. Still, it gathers itself and leans toward light with everything it has, answering invitation with action, making a path where none was given. Hope, here, is not wishful thinking, but the steady orientation toward what sustains, even when all around seems barren and unyielding.

With your brush, sweep a ground of muted grey or rough texture across the page, letting lines fracture and break to suggest the hardness beneath. Then, from a crack, let green rise — tender, luminous, reaching upward without apology. Let your marks be clear and simple, a single gesture of movement toward the possible. The contrast is not a fault, but a truth: life choosing light, again and again.

As you paint, notice the places in yourself that have reached for hope — not because it was easy or certain, but because you could do nothing else.



I feel disappointed.

Let your thoughts linger on a field after harvest, its expanse marked by the ragged stubble of what has been gathered and carried away. The earth is not barren, only spent — its fullness given, its promise kept, the season's work visible in every pale stalk and furrowed row. What remains is not failure but evidence: of tending, of effort, of life that flourished here. The quiet emptiness is not an end, but a pause, a moment of honest rest. Soon, the field will be turned and planted again, the cycle of renewal waiting in the dark beneath.

With your brush, lay down washes of gold and ochre, rough textures and soft shadows, lines that speak of what has been cut and what endures. Let the page hold both absence and memory, the subtle beauty of something that has been given away. There is no need to fill every space; let your painting honour the stubble, the spent earth, the sense of pause before return.

As you paint, consider the places in your own life where you have given all you could — where what is left behind is not defeat but the honest mark of your effort, your care.

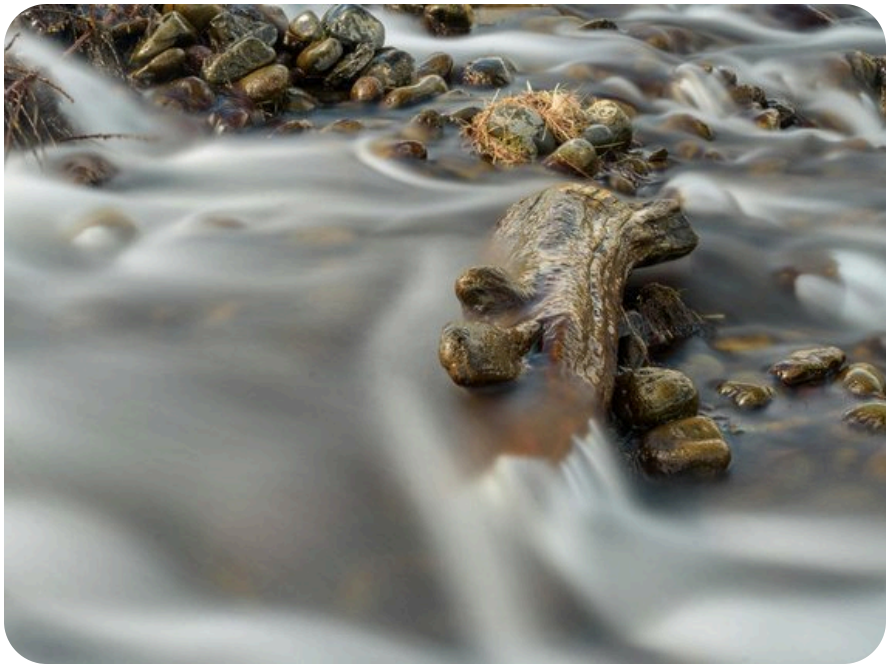


I feel nostalgic.

Let your mind rest on the image of an ancient tree, its trunk thick with years, its centre hollowed by the slow, relentless hand of time. This tree did not lose its heart to weakness, nor was it undone by the hollowing. Instead, the years carved out a space within, leaving a chamber where birds might nest and small creatures shelter. Still, the tree stands — branches outstretched, leaves shimmering in the wind, its roots deep and sure. The hollow is not absence, but memory: the silent vault where each year once lived, a testament to endurance rather than loss.

With your brush, lay down strong, circling shapes — dark rings, rough textures, layers that hint at age and weathering. Let the centre open into a space of quiet, not as a wound, but as a room, a place that holds more than emptiness. Allow soft colours, gentle marks, to gather within the hollow, suggesting shelter, history, the warmth of what remains.

As you paint, consider the spaces within yourself that have been shaped by time— places where something is gone, yet what endures is all the stronger for it.



I feel forgiving.

Let your thoughts drift to a river winding through its valley, its water ceaseless, attentive, caressing the stones in its path. The river does not set out to smooth the rock; it simply keeps moving, day after day, year after year. The stones, steadfast in their resistance, yield not in a single instant, but through the long patience of touch and time. What results is something rounded, polished — beauty shaped by the gentle persistence of flow against hardness. Forgiveness, too, is not a moment but a direction: a slow, steadfast current wearing away what is sharp, not by force, but by returning, again and again, to the work of compassion.

With your brush, lay down broad washes of water and colour, letting them move and settle as they will. Place a shape, a stone, in the stream — let pigment swirl and eddy around it, softening the edges, blurring the divide between what yields and what stands fast. Do not hurry the process; let your painting unfold slowly, tracing the long conversation between flow and form.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself where forgiveness is not yet finished, where hardness and motion continue their quiet meeting.



I feel vulnerable.

Let your mind rest on the image of a hermit crab between shells — soft- bodied and vulnerable, it has outgrown the safety of its old home and, for a moment, must journey exposed across uncertain ground. There is no refuge now, only the press of necessity: to leave behind what no longer fits, to risk the open world in search of the next shelter. This is the most dangerous moment, when all defenses are gone, and yet it is the only way to grow. The crab's courage lies not in bravado, but in the quiet acceptance that transformation demands exposure.

With your brush, lay down the curve of an empty shell, then the hesitant form of the crab reaching out, half-shadow and half-light, moving into open space. Let your colours waver — soft, uncertain, gentle against the harsh edges of what was left behind. Leave part of the page unclaimed, a space of waiting, a place for what is yet to come.

As you paint, consider the times you have found yourself between—no longer sheltered by what once held you, not yet safe in what will.



I feel trusting.

Let your mind linger on the moment a seed loosens its hold and yields itself to the wind. There is no promise in this act, no map of where it will be carried, only the trust that letting go is the beginning of becoming. The seed does not release itself because it knows the destination, but because it knows that staying attached — however safe — would be the greater loss. In this brief flight, uncertainty is not failure but possibility; surrender is not defeat, but faith in what the future might hold.

With your brush, begin with a gentle tether — a thin line, a pod or branch. Then let your marks lift and scatter, drifting across the page in arcs and eddies, as seeds ride on invisible currents. Let colour be light, shapes unanchored, movement the only certainty. Allow empty space to speak of the unknown, to cradle what is not yet rooted.

As you paint, consider your own moments of release — when holding on was no longer growth, and you had to trust the wind.

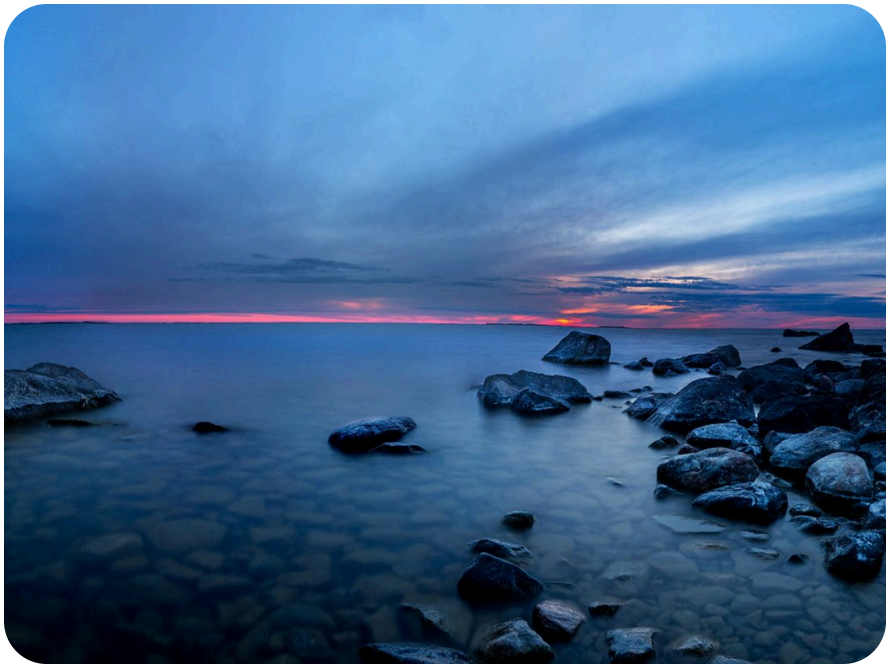


I feel repaired.

Let your thoughts rise to the high perch of the Bald Eagle, circling above the land, returning year after year to the same nest — a tangle of sticks and memory, perched against the wind. The eagle does not abandon its eyrie when the storms have weathered it thin, nor when time has made it heavy. Instead, it returns, faithful, carrying new branches, weaving old with new, repairing what needs mending. Some nests stand for decades, layer upon layer, each season's labour both a remembrance and a renewal. For the eagle, repair is not starting over, but the faithful tending of what has already been built — an act of trust in the enduring strength of home.

With your brush, lay down the broad sweep of a branch, the loose lattice of a nest — marks that overlap, that show the history of many seasons. Let your colours layer and blend, old strokes meeting new, the weight of memory balanced by the freshness of each return. Allow your painting to grow dense in places, a record of care, of presence, of the quiet patience of repair.

As you paint, consider the places in your own life where you return — where you do not begin again from nothing, but meet what has weathered with gentle attention, adding what is needed, mending what has frayed.

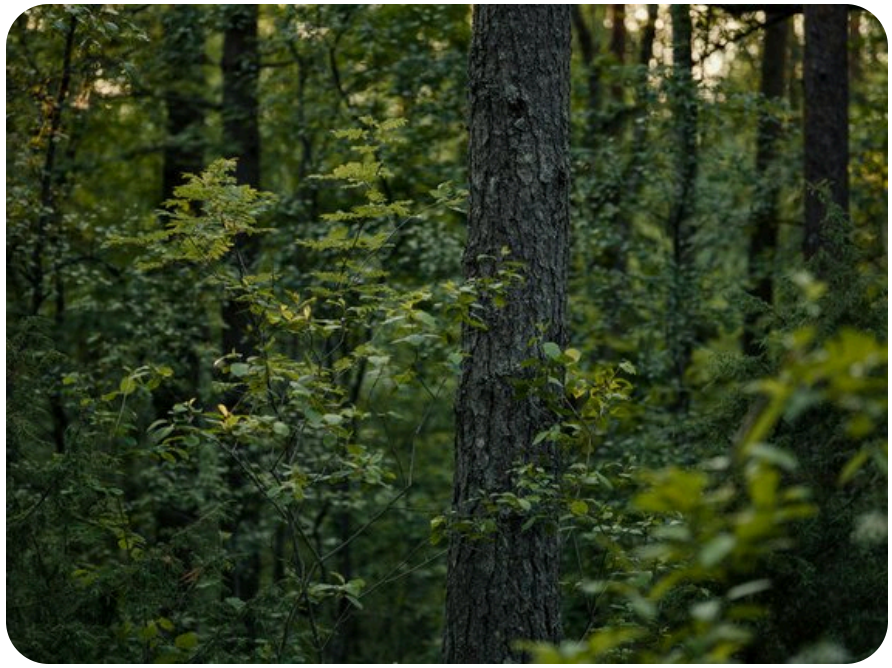


I feel uncertain.

Let your mind wander to a shoreline at dusk, where the last light lingers and boundaries dissolve. Here, the land meets the water, yet neither claims the hour as its own. The sky, too, is not quite night nor day — colours drift, shadows lengthen, certainties blur. This edge of all things, where definitions soften and the world seems to hold its breath, is not a place of confusion but of possibility. Uncertainty is not the enemy of meaning; it is the place where meaning takes shape, where questions gather and answers begin to shimmer, half-formed, in the gathering dark.

With your brush, lay down gentle washes that bleed into one another — blues into golds, land into water, the soft indigo of evening into the hush of sand. Let your marks be loose, your edges undefined, a meeting of forms rather than a division. Allow your painting to dwell in the space between, to hold the ambiguity of dusk, and to honour the beauty of what is not yet decided.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself where you stand on the threshold— uncertain, unfinished, neither one thing nor another.



I feel changed.

Let your thoughts wander through a forest in succession — where nothing stays the same, and yet nothing is truly lost. Here, light first calls up the pioneers: wildflowers, grasses, saplings springing from bare ground. In time, these give way to others, taller, hungrier for sun, their leaves shifting the shape of light below. The canopy thickens, the understory changes, each arrival making space for what comes next. This is not decline, but transformation — the forest becoming what the conditions are ready for, each stage both an ending and a beginning.

With your brush, let colour arrive in layers — bright, loose marks for the first shoots, then deeper greens, branching forms, a gentle shadow across the page as the canopy fills in. Allow some marks to fade, others to emerge more boldly, the painting always in motion, always becoming. There is no need to finish or to fix; let your image shift as the forest does, honouring what was and what is coming into being.

As you paint, consider the seasons of your own life, the ways you have changed and given way to yourself again and again.



I feel grief for the world.

Let your thoughts linger on a glacier in retreat — ancient ice withdrawing, not in defeat, but in honest answer to the changing world. The glacier does not pretend its grief: it melts openly, its sorrow written in streams and rivulets, in the slow, persistent trickle of water finding new paths among exposed stone. What remains is not absence, but potential — bare rock, raw valley, the birth of ground waiting for its first green. The glacier, in its leaving, makes possible the coming of new life, shaping the land even as it recedes.

With your brush, lay down cool, sweeping washes — blues and whites dissolving into dripping trails, edges receding, shapes thinning and soft. Let exposed earth appear, rough and unfinished, where ice has pulled away. Allow the meeting of water and rock to linger, a record of loss and transformation, the beginning of what might grow.

As you paint, consider the places where you have had to let go — not as failure, but as honest response, as the making of space for what comes next.



I feel the ache of not yet.

Let your thoughts rest on a bud in late winter, small but certain, pressed tight against branch or stem. Within that hushed green casing sleeps all the colour and fragrance of the flower to come — life compressed, held patient, shaped not by hurry but by the slow accumulation of readiness. The bud does not force its opening against the frost; it waits, attuned to the subtle promise of warmth, the precise, sweet moment when the world says it is time. Then, and only then, will it release its hidden beauty, unfolding without hesitation into the waiting air.

With your brush, begin with a closed shape — a gentle swell of green, the suggestion of something contained. Let your colours be soft, reserved, hinting at what is held within. Around it, paint the cool hush of late winter: pale blues, muted browns, the quiet of a world not yet awakened. Do not rush to open the bud; let your painting linger in anticipation, in the fullness of what waits.

As you paint, consider the places in yourself where potential rests, patient and whole, not yet called into bloom.

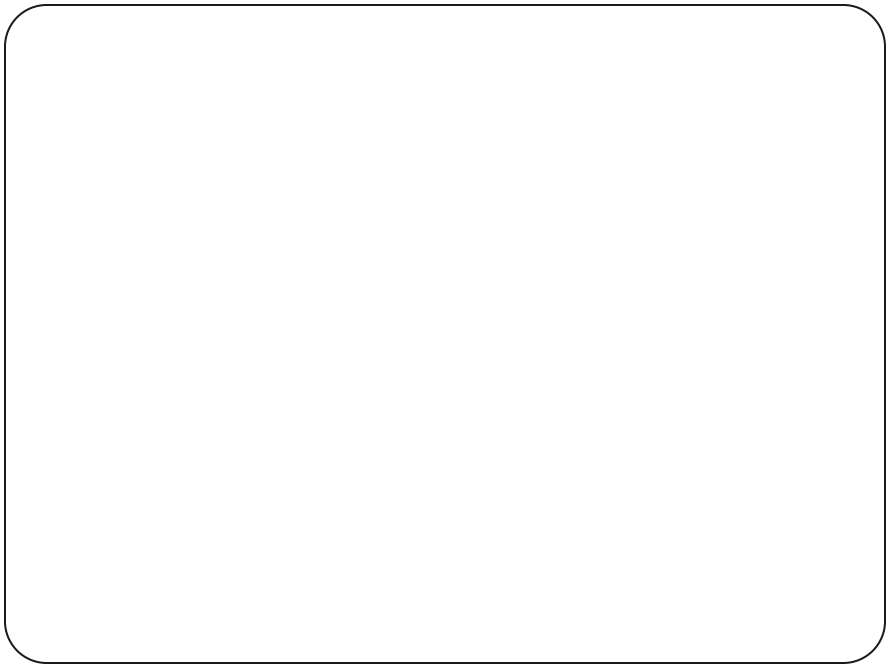


I feel alive.

Let your thoughts settle on the seed in the exact moment of germination — the fragile cusp where possibility collapses into becoming. This is no slow unfolding, but a single, irrevocable act: the seed cracks open, shedding every alternative, committing wholly to one direction, one life. In that instant, every stored hope and memory bursts forth, the darkness split by a green promise. Aliveness, here, is not the long journey ahead, but this unrepeatable moment of full surrender to presence, the fierce and tender choice to be.

With your brush, capture that fracturing — the sharp line where the shell gives way, the emerging shoot delicate yet determined. Let your colours pool and stretch, soft at first, then reaching boldly into space. There is no need to trace the whole story; honour instead this singular point where all converges into one.

As you paint, consider the moments in your own life when you have chosen to be fully here — when you have cracked open, letting go of what might have been for the sake of what is.



I feel _____

Every page prints the same way: Letter paper (8.5 × 11 inches), landscape, at full size. A matte paper or light card stock holds watercolour best. Other Bodies is also available as a deck of cards, with each image on the front and its prompt on the back.

Other Bodies, version 2

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